



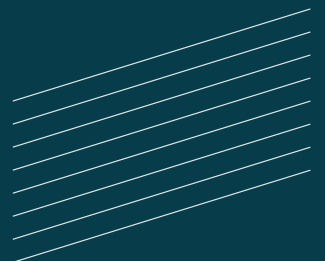
BUILDER EDITION | VERSION 1.0

The Resilience Network Brand & Voice Handbook

The shared strategy, writing standard, and review system for
NowWePlan.com, Cascadia.me, HurricaneCoast.me, and SanAndreas.me.

Prepare for consequences, not for causes.

Built from The Resilience Network Constitution, the Editorial Handbook, and the canonical essay Resilience.
Built for writers, designers, editors, researchers, and site builders.



SECTION 01

Start here

This handbook gives everyone building a Resilience Network site the same starting point. It defines what the network means, how it should relate to readers, how that relationship sounds, and how to tell whether the work is ready.

Use it when you are...

- planning a site, section, page family, or campaign;
- writing or revising editorial, guidance, interface, or promotional copy;
- choosing imagery, interaction patterns, calls to action, or a NowWePlan bridge;
- reviewing work for trust, usefulness, accessibility, and consistency.

The foundation

ORGANIZING PRINCIPLE

Prepare for consequences, not for causes.

Voice test	Relationship test
Use a natural cadence. Would someone actually say this across a kitchen table?	Would you say it this way to someone you care about who is already carrying a lot?

Six rules to carry into every build

- 1 Begin with ordinary life.** Risk matters because daily life matters.
- 2 Recognize before advising.** Name the real friction, then offer help.
- 3 Make one useful move feel possible.** Confidence comes from fit, not slogans.
- 4 Assume unequal capacity.** Cost, tenure, disability, health, transport, space, and time belong in the main guidance.
- 5 Keep authority visible.** Official instructions and qualified professionals retain their proper role.
- 6 Let the reader stop.** Preparation should have an ending.

SECTION 01 / CONTINUED

Find what you need

You do not need to read this handbook front to back before beginning. Use the route that matches the work in front of you, then use the final checklist before anything ships.

IF YOU ARE...	START WITH...
Starting a new site or major section	02 Platform, 03 Beliefs, 04 Relationship, 05 Domains, 12 Visual direction
Planning a page or page family	08 Content structure, 09 Tone by context, 13 Review checklist
Writing or revising copy	04 Relationship, 06 Voice, 07 Humor, 10 Samples
Writing buttons, links, forms, or banners	09 Tone by context, 11 Interface language
Working on live-event or safety content	09 Immediate action, 11 Interface language, 13 Trust
Reviewing work before launch	13 Builder review checklist

Authority

- 1 **The Constitution** sets binding rules.
- 2 **The Brand Platform** defines shared meaning and reader relationship.
- 3 **The Voice Standard** defines cadence and writing practice.
- 4 **This handbook** brings the platform and voice standard together for builders.
- 5 **Domain systems** define local visual and editorial expression.
- 6 **Page briefs** apply the system to a specific task.

If two documents conflict, follow that order. Current local instructions always take precedence during a live event.

What is inside

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SECTION 02

Platform at a glance

The doctrine organizes the work. The reader promise defines the relationship. Neither needs to become a slogan repeated across the network.

Purpose

Help ordinary people make the lives they already have less brittle: understand the places where they live, prepare for interruptions without organizing life around fear, recover faster when systems fail, and build the relationships that make recovery possible.

ORGANIZING PRINCIPLE

Prepare for consequences, not for causes.

Human truth

Most people don't need another reason to worry. They need help making sense of a large subject, recognizing what matters in their own lives, and finding one useful action that fits their circumstances.

Reader promise

We will help you understand what your place can do, make a few useful choices, and know who can help. We will be honest about serious risk without asking you to live in a state of alarm.

Desired outcome

- recognized before being advised;
- clearer about what matters;
- capable of one useful next move;
- less alone;
- free to set the subject down and return to ordinary life.

WHAT THIS MEANS

The network does not tell readers to feel capable. It gives them reasons to believe they may be.

Confidence is earned by fit, clarity, and a manageable action.

SECTION 03

What the brand believes

Ordinary life is the point	Builder implication
Risk matters because water, medication, school, work, animals, routes, homes, and neighbors matter.	Open with the function being protected, not destruction.
Recognition comes before instruction	Builder implication
Advice becomes useful after the page notices what may make it difficult, expensive, awkward, or outside the reader's control.	Name the friction specifically. Skip generic empathy language.
Preparation should have an ending	Builder implication
The network does not seek vigilance or identity. A reader should be able to understand, act, and stop.	Offer one adjacent move, then let the page finish.
Other people are part of the answer	Builder implication
Family, friends, neighbors, organizations, public agencies, health workers, and utility crews all affect what happens next.	Show who can help, share, decide, or hold authority.
Seriousness does not require solemnity	Builder implication
Warmth and mild humor can make unglamorous subjects easier to approach without making light of danger or loss.	Use humor only when the moment is low stakes.
Unequal capacity is assumed	Builder implication
Cost, tenure, disability, health, storage, transport, work, language, and caregiving belong in the main guidance.	Do not bury alternatives in an accessibility appendix.
Authority stays visible	Builder implication
Official agencies issue alerts and instructions. Qualified professionals assess buildings, health, insurance, and other specialized questions.	Make the handoff explicit and easy to reach.
Trust comes before conversion	Builder implication
Every regional site is complete on its own. NowWePlan is optional continuity, not the missing payoff.	Complete the public task before mentioning a private tool.

SECTION 04

The reader relationship

The network is a knowledgeable person across a kitchen table. It is not a coach, a campaign, or an institution performing warmth.

The reader may arrive...

- curious, skeptical, tired, frightened, or busy;
- short on money, space, time, transport, or control over a building;
- caring for a child, older adult, animal, or someone with medical needs;
- comfortable with risk information or actively avoiding it;
- during a quiet afternoon or a frightening night.

The emotional movement

- 1 **Recognition:** This understands the life I actually have.
- 2 **Orientation:** I can see what matters and what doesn't.
- 3 **Choice:** There is something useful I could do.
- 4 **Support:** I don't have to solve every part alone.
- 5 **Release:** I have done enough for now.

What changes in the writing

INTERNAL / AVOID	READER-FACING / PREFER
We know this can feel overwhelming.	The list gets long quickly, especially when every item seems to need money or somewhere to store it.
You have got this.	A few bottles won't cover a long outage, but they're a useful beginning.
Take control of your preparedness.	Write down the medication and the dose.
Protect what matters most.	Keep medication cold during an outage.
Start your resilience journey.	Choose a meeting place.

THE STANDARD

Connect first. Clarify second. Encourage only when it has been earned.

SECTION 05

Domain expressions

The domains share a doctrine and a relationship with readers. They do not share a costume or a stack of slogans.

NowWePlan.com

Role: Keep the plan alive

Reader tension: Most plans don't disappear because people don't care. They disappear under everything else.

Expression: Practical, companionable, good at remembering, and respectful of incomplete progress.

Cascadia.me

Role: Understand the place

Reader tension: Cascadia is beautiful, complicated, and capable of interrupting ordinary life in several overlapping ways.

Expression: Geographically observant, explanatory, and attentive to land, water, weather, infrastructure, buildings, routes, and communities.

HurricaneCoast.me

Role: Live through the season

Reader tension: By late summer, people may be tired of being told to prepare or still recovering from the last event.

Expression: Seasonally aware, unsensational, and honest about leaving, return, insurance, housing, heat, transport, and repeated recovery.

SanAndreas.me

Role: Prepare without an appointment

Reader tension: Earthquakes offer no annual moment when attention naturally becomes available.

Expression: Matter-of-fact, building-literate, attentive to immediate action and long domestic consequences, and resistant to countdowns.

Four sample openings

NOWWEPLAN.COM

Most plans don't fail because nobody cared. They get buried under work, school, appointments, and the rest of the week. This is a place to find the loose ends and decide what's worth doing next.

CASCADIA.ME

Most days, Cascadia works quietly around us. The tap runs, the road is open, the lights come on, and the river stays where we expect it. This site is about the days one of those things doesn't happen, and the few choices that can make those days easier.

HURRICANECOAST.ME

By August, nobody needs another reminder that it's hurricane season. The useful question is what would make leaving, staying, or coming home a little less difficult this time.

SANANDREAS.ME

Earthquakes don't offer a season to get ready. That's inconvenient, but it also means you don't need to treat preparation as an annual performance. Fix what matters, make a few arrangements, and revisit them when life changes.

SECTION 06

Voice and cadence

Natural cadence is not casual decoration. It is how the network avoids sounding computed, institutional, or evangelistic.

Use contractions

Contractions are the default in reader-facing prose: you're, don't, can't, it's, that's, won't, you'll, and we've. Keep an uncontracted form only when it adds deliberate emphasis or preserves an exact quotation.

INTERNAL / AVOID	READER-FACING / PREFER
You do not need to finish everything today.	You don't need to finish everything today.
This will not fit every household.	This won't fit every household.
If that is not workable...	If that isn't workable...
You cannot solve all of that in advance.	You can't solve all of that in advance.

Stop when the line lands

Overstretched	Natural
Write down medication names, doses, and prescribers. "The small white one" is a poor description even on an ordinary Tuesday.	Write down medication names, doses, and prescribers. "The small white one" is a poor description.

Sentence habits

- Prefer concrete nouns and direct verbs.
- Vary sentence length for a reason.
- Use second person for relevance, not blame or presumed emotion.
- Make room for different choices and real tradeoffs.
- Read important copy aloud at normal speed.
- Cut a sentence when you would say it more simply to a real person.

Words that usually need a second look

INTERNAL / AVOID	READER-FACING / PREFER
facilitate, empower, operationalize	help, make, decide, record
leverage, optimize, activate	use, improve, begin
dependent reunification protocol	where the household will meet
increase household water resilience	keep water where you can reach it
navigate uncertainty	decide what to do with incomplete information

SECTION 07

Mild conversational humor

Humor can make awkward, unglamorous subjects easier to approach. The situation may be inconvenient, awkward, or faintly absurd. The reader is never the joke.

Good subjects

- containers that need somewhere to live;
- paperwork and the number of mugs in a cupboard;
- chargers that haven't been charged;
- bags that are too heavy;
- food nobody in the household likes;
- the awkwardness of beginning a neighbor conversation;
- the fact that toilets require systems.

Off limits

- active danger, evacuation, and shelter instructions;
- injury, death, grief, displacement, or material loss;

- poverty, disability, illness, immigration status, or housing insecurity;
- a reader's lack of preparation;
- official warnings, uncertainty, or harmful institutional failure.

Samples

WATER

Water takes up a surprising amount of space for something that normally arrives through a wall. Decide where it'll live before buying containers.

SANITATION

This is the part everyone hopes another guide will cover. Unfortunately, the toilet won't become self-sufficient.

MEDICATION

Write down medication names, doses, and prescribers. "The small white one" is a poor description.

POWER

Check the battery pack occasionally. A backup at three percent is mostly a rectangle.

FOOD

Store food your household already eats. An outage isn't a good time to introduce everyone to lentils.

NEIGHBORS

You don't need a committee or a clipboard. A name, a phone number, and a short conversation will do.

Delivery

- Keep the useful information intact.
- Use understatement rather than a setup and punchline.
- Usually allow no more than one light line in a section.
- Do not call attention to the joke.
- Do not add a second phrase after it lands.
- Remove humor that competes with clarity or may not translate.

SECTION 08

How content carries meaning

This is a meaning hierarchy, not a mandatory page template. Repeating the same verbal structure across every page will make the network sound manufactured.

- 1 **Ordinary life:** Begin with the recognizable function, place, routine, or constraint.
- 2 **Recognition:** Name why the issue may be difficult, easy to postpone, or different across households.
- 3 **Explanation:** Clarify the physical system, consequence, or decision.
- 4 **Useful action:** Offer a proportionate next move and explain why it helps.
- 5 **Fit:** Include alternatives for cost, tenure, mobility, space, health, caregiving, transport, and time.
- 6 **Connection:** Identify who else may help, share, decide, repair, or hold authority.
- 7 **Evidence:** Show the source, boundary, uncertainty, and review date.
- 8 **Release:** Let the reader stop or choose one adjacent move.

Public questions, not internal taxonomy

INTERNAL / AVOID	READER-FACING / PREFER
Capability model	How do I keep water available?
Consequence library	What if the power stays out?
Journey stage	What should I do first?
Structural mitigation	What should I ask about my building?
Continuity layer	How will we remember the next step?
Authority directory	Who is responsible for this place?

A USEFUL ENDING

If you know where the water will go and have filled the first container, you can leave the rest for another day.

End when the thought is complete. Do not add inspiration because the page is ending.

SECTION 09

Tone by context

CONTEXT	POSTURE	HUMOR
Evergreen editorial	Observant, explanatory, and companionable. Natural paragraphs with varied sentence length.	Available in small amounts.
Household guidance	Specific, realistic, and nonjudgmental. Clear action with enough explanation to support judgment.	Useful when it reduces awkwardness.
Immediate action	Direct, brief, and explicit. Current official instruction takes precedence.	None.
Recovery and loss	Patient, honest, and restrained. Give difficult facts room. Do not rush toward uplift.	Usually none. Never near grief or material loss.
Buildings and health	State the limit, then help the reader ask a better question.	Rare.
Interface copy	Plain and quiet. Familiar labels over branded language.	Only in low-stakes, reversible moments, if at all.

Immediate-action sample

EARTHQUAKE

If the ground is moving, Drop, Cover, and Hold On. If you're near the coast and the shaking is strong or lasts a long time, move inland or to high ground as soon as you can do so safely. Follow current local instructions.

No humor. No campaign language. The official action and handoff stay clear.

Recovery sample

MONTH THREE

Recovery is often a series of ordinary problems made harder: finding a place to stay, reaching work, replacing medication, documenting damage, and telling the same story to another office. You can't solve all of that in advance. You may be able to remove one or two complications.

The passage does not hurry toward inspiration.

Technical-boundary sample

BUILDING

A map can't tell you whether this building is safe. It can help you identify the ground conditions and the questions to take to a qualified professional.

State the limit, then preserve usefulness.

SECTION 10

Copy samples

These samples demonstrate the relationship and cadence. They are not mandatory network copy.

CASCADIA.ME HOMEPAGE OPENING

Living here comes with a few things worth knowing.

Most days, the tap runs, the road is open, the lights come on, and the river stays where we expect it. This site is about the days one of those things doesn't happen, and the few choices that can make those days easier.

Links: See what happens here Start with the household

The opening begins with ordinary function. It does not ask the reader to join a movement.

WATER

Where will the water go?

Storing water sounds simple until you picture the containers: where they'll fit, whether you can lift them, and how much they cost. Start with the space you actually have. A few bottles in a cupboard won't cover a long outage, but they're more useful than an ideal supply you have nowhere to keep.

First step: Fill one clean container and choose where it'll live.

Recognition precedes the action. The encouragement is proportionate.

MEDICATION

Make the instructions easy to find.

Write down medication names, doses, and prescribers. "The small white one" is a poor description. Add the pharmacy, allergies, and anything that must stay cold or powered. Keep a copy where another person could find it.

The humor is brief and contained inside useful guidance.

PEOPLE NEARBY

Start with one person.

Talking with a neighbor about emergencies can feel oddly intimate, especially if you usually exchange little more than a wave. You don't need a committee or a clipboard. A name, a phone number, and a short conversation will do.

The page acknowledges the awkwardness instead of covering it with encouragement.

LIVE-EVENT BANNER

Current instructions for this area

You don't need to sort through this alone. [Authority] has the current instructions for [place].

Action: Read the official notice

No humor. No paraphrased order. The authority handoff comes first.

SECTION 11

Interface and action language

Buttons should describe a real task. They should not supply emotion that the surrounding copy has failed to earn.

INTERNAL / AVOID	READER-FACING / PREFER
Learn more	Read what this map can show
Get started	Choose a meeting place
Take action	Find your local alert service
Be ready	Print the medication page
Keep exploring	Show official sources
Unlock your plan	Save the next step
No data	No recent report found

Calls to action

- Write the task on the button or link.
- Use a button only when the reader is genuinely changing tasks.
- Let ordinary continuation remain a text link or the next paragraph.

- Do not turn every section into a conversion opportunity.
- Complete the public task before offering NowWePlan.

NowWePlan bridge sample

OPTIONAL CONTINUITY

If you want help keeping track of owners, next steps, review dates, and practice, NowWePlan can hold the plan. The guidance here remains complete without it.

Trust before conversion. No household information moves without explicit action.

Share-language sample

NEUTRAL DEFAULT

I found this Cascadia.me page useful. It explains [page subject] and links to the sources responsible for this place.

Prefer page-specific language when available. Avoid describing every surface as a guide.

SECTION 12

Visual and experience direction

Shared meaning, local expression

The regional sites share doctrine, research standards, accessibility, and technical infrastructure. They should still feel native to their places. Cascadia is not California with different mountains. Hurricane country is not a generic coastline.

Show

- ordinary life before spectacle;
- place as lived environment, not scenery;
- people doing recognizable things rather than performing preparedness;
- useful objects in context rather than equipment displays;
- recovery through domestic and civic life;
- diagrams that clarify dependencies, time, and authority;
- clear visual distinction between editorial explanation and official information.

Avoid

- disaster imagery chosen mainly to frighten;
- tactical or militarized aesthetics;
- gear arranged as competence or identity;

- heroic households untouched by loss;
- generic regional scenery applied to generic advice;
- interface density used to imply authority;
- a shared network costume that flattens local difference.

Reachability

Essential content must remain useful on old devices, poor connections, and paper. Pages should work without images and remain comprehensible without color. Interactive tools need meaningful static fallbacks. Live or official material must show source identity and recency.

EXPERIENCE PRINCIPLE

A page that cannot be read during an outage has failed at the thing it exists to do.

SECTION 13

Builder review checklist

Read the page once for meaning, once aloud for cadence, and once as a reader with less control than the builder assumed.

Relationship

- Does the page recognize before it advises?
- Does it sound adult to adult?
- Does it leave room for skepticism, ambivalence, and different choices?
- Does it avoid manufacturing intimacy or encouragement?

Cadence

- Are contractions used where someone would naturally use them?
- Does sentence length vary for a reason?
- Can any sentence stop earlier?
- Has a joke, image, or conclusion been explained after it landed?
- Would these words be said across a kitchen table?

Usefulness

- Is the first useful action proportionate?
- Does the reader know why it helps?
- Are alternatives available for money, space, tenure, mobility, health, transport, caregiving, and time?

- Is institutional responsibility visible where household action is not enough?

Humor

- Is the situation the subject rather than the reader?
- Is the moment low stakes?
- Does the line survive without a second explanatory phrase?
- Would removing it make the instruction clearer or kinder?

Trust

- Are official instruction, guidance, evidence, history, interpretation, and fiction distinct?
- Are uncertainty and source limits stated plainly?
- Does current local authority clearly take precedence?
- Can the reader act and then set the subject down?

FINAL DECISION

If the work passes the constitutional test but fails the relationship test, it is not ready.

Source documents

The Resilience Network Constitution, version 1.0; The Resilience Network Editorial Handbook, version 1.0; and Resilience, the canonical network essay. The Constitution governs wherever the documents conflict.